

SEDAR 48 Southeastern U.S. Black Grouper

Data Workshop

Life History Working Group:

Given that there may be some possible connectivity with the Campeche Banks, some genetic samples from *M. bonaci* from this area should be sought for comparison with specimens from the West Florida Shelf, the Florida Keys, and Southeast Florida. However, local recruitment is still thought to be the main contributor to the population in U.S. southeastern waters. Further genetic sampling of *M. bonaci* from the areas of the southeastern US (Texas to North Carolina) may be warranted to assess whether there is any genetic structuring in *M. bonaci* in U.S. southeastern waters.

Commercial Fishery Statistics Working Group:

- • More observer coverage for the snapper-grouper fishery
- • Expand TIP sampling to better cover all statistical strata
- • Trade off with lengths versus ages, need for more ages (i.e., hard parts)
- • Historical species identification (mis-identification and unclassified)

Recreational Fishery Statistics Working Group:

No Research Recommendations were provided.

Indices of relative Abundance Working Group:

Only one fishery-independent index was available for Black Grouper (Reef Visual Census), and that index may suffer from hyperstability because it is limited primarily to the center of distribution for Black Grouper in the region. Accordingly, the index working group recommends that additional fishery-independent survey effort would be extremely valuable in assessing trends in population abundance of Black Grouper. Such efforts would include an expansion of survey effort beyond the core distribution of the species, including better coverage of the spawning-capable portion of the stock (potentially through the use of expanded underwater video surveys), and efforts to characterize juvenile recruitment.